

**Fifth Instruction for Father Barzaeus,
on Avoiding Scandals**

From Goa, between April 6 and 14, 1552
(EX II 431-434; FX 544-545)

118.

Summary: 1-3. Conduct with women. 4-8. What he should do when husband and wife are quarreling. 9. Prudence in all things. 10. Corrections should be made without anger. 11. Relations with priests and religious. 12. Patience in adversities. 13-14. Disagreements between members of the Society and other religious.

Portuguese, from the original text of the scribe

†
Jhs.

The way to deal with the world and to avoid scandals

1. Converse with all women, of whatever state and condition they may be, in a public place, for example, in a church; never go to their homes except in a case of extreme necessity, for example, in order to hear their confession when they are ill.

When you go to their homes in a case of extreme necessity, it will be with her husband, or with those who have charge of her house, or with neighbors who have charge of her house.

When it will be to a woman who is not married, go to her house with a person who is known in the neighborhood or in the land as a good man in order to avoid any scandal. By this I mean when there is a great need for doing so; for if she is well, she will come to the church, as I have said above.

2. These visits will be made as little as possible, since they involve great risks and little is gained for the increase of the service of God.

3. Since women are generally inconstant, lacking in perseverance, and take up much time, you should deal with them in the following way: If they are married, take great care to work with their husbands so that they come to God; and spend more time in producing fruit among husbands than among wives,

¹⁷ Barzaeus sent the petition at the end of 1552 or beginning of 1553 (DI II 603-612).

since more fruit follows from this, for men are more constant and the management of the house depends upon them; in this way numerous scandals are avoided and more fruit is gained.

4. When there are quarrels between a wife and her husband which lead to requests for a separation, always attempt to reconcile them, talking more with the husband than with his wife, striving to induce them to make a general confession, giving them some meditations from the First Week before you absolve them. Be slow in absolving them, so that they may become more disposed and live in the service of God.

5. Do not believe the pious aspirations of women who say that they would serve God better if they were separated from their husbands instead of living with them, for these are only pious aspirations that are of short duration, and they are seldom effected without scandal. Avoid blaming the husband in public, even though he is at fault; advise him in secret to make a general confession, and in his confession you will correct him with great modesty. Be careful that he does not get the impression that you are favoring his wife rather than him, even though he is to blame; you should rather induce him to accuse himself. Then, on the basis of his accusation, you should condemn him with much love, charity, and meekness; for with these men in India, much is gained by asking, but nothing by force.

6. Take care, as I say again, never to blame the husband in public, even though he is at fault, for women are so indomitable that they look for occasions to belittle their husbands, alleging to religious persons that their husbands are to blame and not themselves.

Even if the wives are not to blame, do not excuse them as they excuse themselves, but rather show them the obligation they have of putting up with their husbands, for they are frequently disrespectful to them and thus deserve some punishment; and that they should patiently accept their present difficulties and be induced to be humble, patient, and obedient to their husbands.

7. Do not believe everything which they tell you, whether it be husband or wife; listen to both of them before attributing the blame to anyone, and do not show greater favor towards one than towards the other, since in these cases both are always at fault, even though one may be more so than the other; and be very slow in accepting the excuses of those who are guilty. I am telling you this so that they may be more easily reconciled and avoid giving scandal.

8. When you are not able to reconcile them, send them to the lord bishop or to the vicar general; and do not quarrel with them on any account, for example, by blaming one and not the other.

9. Take care to use much prudence with this wicked world, attending closely to what could happen, since the devil never sleeps. Be sure that it is very imprudent not to fear the difficulties which can follow the works we do, even though they may be motivated by a good intention. Because of a lack of prudence, through failure to take into account eventual difficulties, many evils at times arise.

10. See to it that you never correct anyone in anger, since persons of the world never profit from such corrections: they attribute everything to this

imperfection and nothing at all to the zeal with which it is said, since they are themselves very imperfect.

11. Be ever humble and abased in your dealings with friars and priests,¹ letting their anger and passion run their course.² I mean this not only when you are at fault, but even when you are not to blame and they are. You should seek no greater revenge than that of remaining silent when you are right, when what is right is neither heard nor esteemed. Have pity on them when they do something wrong, for sooner or later they will be punished by God far more than what you or they think; have compassion therefore upon them, and always pray to God for them. Do not seek for any other revenge, neither in thoughts nor in words nor in deeds, since these are dangerous and harmful, and all else is but flesh and blood.

12. Know for sure and do not doubt that God grants many graces and favors to those who suffer persecution through love for him and show respect to those who persecute them, if they patiently endure their persecutions. God will take special care to confound those who persecute you by impeding your pious works; but God will cease to do so if you seek to take revenge on them either through your thoughts, works, or words.

13. If it should happen—may God prevent it—that there should be any quarrels between you and the friars, be careful not to indulge in harsh words with them in the presence of the governor or of people of the world, since people of the world are not edified by this. But if it should happen that in their sermons or conversations religious should mention some things in which they disagree with you, speak to the lord bishop; and meet with them in his presence so that the lord bishop can put an end to these disputes; and tell the lord bishop on my behalf that he should handle this himself without the intervention of any layman.

14. Be attentive not to speak against them from the pulpit, even though they should say some things against us; but rather, as I have said, speak with the lord bishop so that he may summon both you and them and prevent any quarrels from becoming public, since the people are greatly disedified and scandalized by these. And note well that the good name of the Society does not consist in the esteem and approval of the world, but in that of God alone, who wishes us to avoid all scandal, anger, and discords. I strongly recommend that you act in this way, as I am ordering you under obedience to do; and see to it that in all your controversies you have recourse to the lord bishop, to whose judgment and opinion you are subject, earnestly asking him as a favor to impose peace where the enemy is sowing discord.

[In Xavier's hand:] FRANCISCO.

¹ Members of the secular and regular clergy.

² Cf. Rom 12.19.